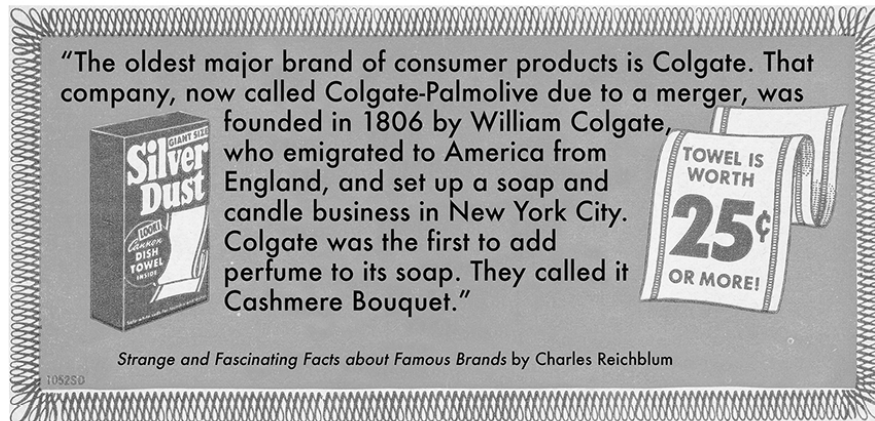




By 1965, more than half of the people in the United States reported using coupons. Ten years later, that number grew to 75 percent. By the end of the twentieth century, using coupons had become a part of shopping for the majority of families. According to Inmar, a network of independent marketing consultants, the peak year for coupon redemption was 1992, at the end of the last recession, when 7.9 billion coupons were redeemed. This period was followed by a fifteen-year decline in use. Still, coupons had become a natural way of life for most families. So much so that in 1998 the United States designated September as "National Coupon Month," despite the fact that in 2007, less than 3 percent of all manufacturers' coupons distributed via newspapers, magazines, or in the mail were actually redeemed.

Slumps in the economy do seem to contribute to resurgence in their use. According to Inmar, an increase in redemption was noted in October 2008, when the US financial crisis hit. Over three billion coupons were redeemed in 2009, a 27 percent leap from the 2.6 billion redeemed in 2008. Marketers responded in kind, by increasing the number of coupons distributed to the